

Council Meeting
January 6, 2018
Page 3

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Saturday, January 6, 2018, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 9:00 a.m.

Members of the Council present were:

At-Large Councilor Claire Lessard
Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone
Assistant Mayor Allen Damren
Mayor Charlene Lovett
At-Large Councilor Jeremy Zullo
At-Large Councilor Abigail Kier (late)
Ward II Councilor Scott Pope

Absent:

At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski

Also present:

Ryan McNutt, City Manager

NEW BUSINESS

New Councilor Orientation/Training

Mayor Lovett said the purpose of this meeting is to ensure all Councilors have the same background information.

Mayor Lovett covered the history of the Charter.

At 9:05 a.m. Ms. Kier arrived.

There was a discussion about the Charter, Section 20. - Dealings of Councilors and that any bid that a Councilor wished to participate in would have to be done by sealed bid. Mr. McNutt suggested that may be something to confirm with legal counsel. Mr. Stone said he is in the weapons business and his company has worked with the Police Department. Mr. McNutt will ask for a legal opinion.

Mayor Lovett said the Council is responsible to hire and fire the City Manager and to evaluate him.

Council Meeting

January 6, 2018

Page 4

Mr. McNutt said he has an open-door policy and that Councilors can bring any comments/concerns to him.

Mayor Lovett said if Councilors ask department heads questions, they should also include the City Manager. She said the Council does not have the authority to direct City staff nor can any Councilor individually direct the City Manager.

Regarding salaries, Mayor Lovett said Council approves the fiscal side of the union contracts and the Merit Plan.

Mr. McNutt said new salaries would probably be proposed next year.

Mayor Lovett said the Council has the authority to ask the City Manager for information. Also, Ms. Russell, Council Clerk, is another resource.

There was a discussion about the budget. Mr. McNutt said he will submit the budget to the Council on May 2nd.

Mr. Damren talked about section 37. - Financial Control of the Charter and that it references an auditor. He didn't think there was an auditor in the City, so he suggested there may need to be an amendment to change that title. Mayor Lovett asked Mr. McNutt to check that with legal counsel.

There was a discussion about the Personnel Advisory Board and the seat that is appointed by the Council is vacant.

Mayor Lovett talked about modifying the Charter and that the Council has the authority to start the amendment process. Major changes to the Charter would require a Charter Commission.

Mayor Lovett said Council Rules help the meetings run as efficiently as possible.

Mayor Lovett asked Mr. Pope to be the Sergeant-at-Arms and he accepted.

Mr. McNutt said when former City Solicitor Jane Taylor retired, the City elected to hire an outside legal firm, Gardner Fulton & Waugh from Lebanon. Council can ask them questions, but there is a financial cost to doing that.

Mayor Lovett said that legal counsel represents the City as a whole. She said individual Councilors should not contact Gardner, Fulton & Waugh directly as there is a cost to that. She said legal questions can be asked through NHMA (NH Municipal Association) and they don't charge. They usually respond within 24 hours.

Mayor Lovett talked about meetings and the process for getting items on the agenda. She said her objective is to have the meetings last no later than 9:30 p.m. She said if Councilors see a better way to do it, they should suggest changes to the Council Rules.

Mayor Lovett brought up the Committee Reports item on the agenda and that reports are rarely received from the boards, commissions or committees. After discussion, Mayor Lovett said she would draft, on behalf of the Council, a generic memo to ask boards, commissions or committees to put an executive summary item on their agenda which will be reported to the Council. She'll bring the draft back to the Council.

Mayor Lovett said she has no authority to enforce this, but she asked that Councilors come to the meetings dressed in accordance with their positions. She also said to avoid chewing gum.

Ms. Kier asked if the board application can state it is expected that board members will dress appropriately. Mr. McNutt said he can ask if that is legal.

Mayor Lovett said the current Master Plan is dated 2011. A new Master Plan is coming soon and Council will use its goals & objectives to help evaluate the City Manager.

Regarding reference resources, Mayor Lovett said she keeps the Council's copy of the City Code book with her because she is always looking at it.

There was a discussion about policies and that they should be reviewed every five years. The Policy Committee members were Scott Pope, Abigail Kier and John Simonds. [Note: Committee members will need to be reappointed for this current Council term.]

Mr. Pope said the lead policy will come out as soon as he is given the information.

Mayor Lovett talked about the Fund Balance Policy. Mr. Damren, who was on the Finance Committee said the City is okay with its fund balance. He's waiting for the new audit report. Mayor Lovett was also on the Finance Committee. They will be looking for a third Council member for that committee. [Note: Committee members will need to be reappointed for this current Council term.]

Mayor Lovett said she is working with the City Manager to create a dashboard for the City Manager's Report to get a quick view of the fiscal health of the City.

Mr. Damren said the next big item for the Finance Committee is to establish reserve funds for the Water and Sewer Departments.

Regarding joint meetings of the City Council and the School Board, Mayor Lovett said it is her priority to have productive joint meetings. The purpose for joint meetings is to discuss what affects all (i.e. budgets and the lead issue).

Mr. McNutt said the City and the schools have a symbiotic relationship. The reputation of the schools is important for economic development. He said he meets regularly with School Superintendent Dr. Middleton McGoodwin.

Council Meeting
January 6, 2018
Page 6

Mayor Lovett told the Councilors not to communicate directly with each other. If they want to share information, forward it to Ms. Russell and she will distribute it.

There was a discussion about the City and schools' online profiles. Mr. McNutt said one problem is a lack of workforce which is affecting businesses coming here. We have an underutilized technical school. That entity could be a partner with the City.

Mayor Lovett told Councilors to look at the 2017 Goals & Objectives and then think about what they want to do in 2018.

Mayor Lovett said there will be a non-public session at the January 24th Council meeting to discuss the City Manager's evaluation.

Mayor Lovett said there will be a water/sewer presentation at the January 10th Council meeting.

She asked Councilors to think about whether or not they would like to have tours of the City departments.

Mayor Lovett said NHMA offers training. Someone could come here at a cost of about \$400. There are also webinars. Town & City magazine has a list of trainings that are available.

ADJOURNMENT

At 11:58 a.m., a motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Ms. Kier to adjourn.

Voice vote: motion carried 8-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council